Nehru vs the Sangh: The Debate in India's First Election Campaign

Nehru single-handedly changed the political discourse on the Hindu refugee question and secularism in a very divided Congress. His refusal to concede to majority opinion, his deep personal commitment to the democratic ideal of a non-Hindu state, and his ability as a mass politician to impose his will through oratorical ability and sheer force of personality swung the debate on the Hindu–Muslim question. This explains the deep personal antagonism to Nehru that persists among Hindu nationalists to this day.

Nehru defined the fight against Hindu nationalism as India's primary political challenge. In December 1951, speaking at a rally in Bhopal, he bunched together the Jan Sangh, the Hindu Mahasabha[53] and the Ram Rajya Parishad as forces that would make the country weak. 'They had no economic or political programme,' Nehru argued. They were 'raising false slogans of religion and culture to confuse the people'. It was deplorable, that 'leaders of these organisations should have the cheek to exploit the religious sentiments of the people to further their political ends'.

The prime minister pointed out what might be seen as an early example of fake news: that 'fantastic lies' were being spread about the Hindu Code Bill, and that he had been told by some people in Gwalior that, under the Hindu Code, 'brothers and sisters would marry each other'.[54] The Sangh, Nehru felt, was funded by jagirdars, zamindars and capitalists, not because they were religious-minded but because they were taking shelter behind such groups to shield privileges that were now under threat.[55] Nehru was pitting the mass of Indians who were not privileged or monied against those with lineage, power and wealth. His reference to Gwalior in central India, an old Hindu Mahasabha base and home to the royal dynasty of the Scindias, was telling, as he blended into his narrative the class, privilege and religiosity of his opponents.

Nehru had threatened to crush the Jan Sangh. In response, the new party was on the defensive from Day 1. In rally after rally, Mookerjee kept returning to the theme that this was a sign of